BORN AS A QUESTION

bad with a grand Musi riverfront. It's a tough, controversial task

Reddy's Congress government has now embarked on the grandest such initiative—the Musi Riverfront Development project, cast as a mission to "reconnect Hyderabad with its river".

No living memory endures of a Hyderabad slung, like a pearl necklace, around the Musi. For locals, it's just a *naala* choking with plastic and industrial effluents. Yet, the waters of the Musi had brought Quli Qutb Shah here—to found the city. The Charminar, which he built in 1591, stands a mile off its banks, the centrepiece of a riverfront grid—though most visitors miss this fact. A century ago, the iconic M. Visvesvaraya reimagined Hyderabad as a modern city linked organically to the Musi, its waters controlled by dams.

Recovering that vision, though, is turning into a costly and controversial task. For much of its course, the Musi is encroached upon by thousands of residential and commercial constructions. Reclamation would be impossible without large-scale displacement and livelihood disruption—10,000-odd structures face demolition.

The Bharat Rashtra Samithi sees its humongous budget, purportedly over Rs 1 lakh crore in its entirety, as a sieve for corruption. A detailed project report (DPR) is still in the works, but the CM has unveiled a five-phase Master Vision. The Rs 1,500 crore outlay in 2026-27 is the starting capital for Phase 1, covering 21 km out of 55, which needs Rs 6,500-7,000 crore, excluding land acquisition. Besides the Rs 20,000 crore he has sought from the Centre, Revanth plans to approach multilateral agencies.

Takeaways

- **CM plans ambitious Musi riverfront for Hyderabad**
- **Five-phase plan purportedly needs Rs 1 lakh crore in all**
- **Project will need to uproot thousands of constructions**



UNDER STRESS A stretch of the Musi River in Hyderabad

A GLOBAL PRACTICE

The CM says rivals are "blockading" a "growth engine" that would prevent flooding, stimulate tourism and real estate development, and redefine sustainable urban living. He says cities around the world are turning riverfronts into economic powerhouses. In the past two years, Revanth has led officials on study tours to riverfronts in Seoul (Cheonggyecheon), Tokyo (Sumida), London, Singapore as well as the Dubai Creek.

Part of the plan: new sewage treatment plants to detoxify the Musi, and 2.5 tmc of Godavari waters to pep up its seasonal flow. A Gandhi Sarovar at Bapu Ghat, where a portion of Mahatma Gandhi's ashes were immersed in 1948, would be the high point, literally. This intersection of Phase 1 and 2 is to have a massive statue of the Father of the Nation, plus a museum, research centre and handloom training centre.

A 200-acre grandiosity built on evictions? Activists, including Mahatma Gandhi's great-grandson Tushar Gandhi, say it's very un-Gandhian. The BRS, which spurned the CM's invite for talks, calls it "lootification". Residents of Madhu Park Ridge, which has 500 flats facing doom, are close to satyagraha. ■